

# A MOMENTOUS PACT

AFP PHOTO FARUQ NAEM



**FRIENDS IN NEED:**  
Sharif (left) and Zardari  
united at Murree

**Former rivals Zardari and Sharif come together to force Musharraf out and give Pakistan's return to democracy its best shot but party dissension could upset their calculations**

■ **By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi**

**W**ith President Pervez Musharraf finally calling a session of the newly-elected parliament on March 17, it would seem that the clouds of uncertainty are beginning to dissipate from Pakistan's political horizon. Two days before the announcement from the presidency, Asif Ali Zardari and Nawaz Sharif—the heads of the two largest parties in parliament—came together on March 9 in the hill resort of Bhurban near Murree to sign what many called a “historic declaration”.

The Murree Declaration, as it has come to be known, reaffirmed a

power-sharing arrangement between the erstwhile foes and ostensibly smoothed out differences over the two most contentious issues for the coalition—the restoration of the judiciary and participation of the Sharif-led Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) in government. On the touchy issue of the sacking of judges by General Musharraf on November 3, 2007—which Zardari's Pakistan Peoples' Party (PPP) seemed to have been dragging its feet over—the declaration said that the parliament would pass a resolution restoring the judiciary within 30 days of the convening of the National Assembly. And on the issue of PML(N) taking up cabinet posts, Sharif

seemed to have backed down from his earlier insistence that none of his legislators could take their oath of office from “the illegitimate” President. More importantly, the joint declaration put to rest some of the rumours of a widening rift between the two main democratic forces in Pakistan.

But despite the near-unanimous public approval of the Murree Declaration, there are a number of tricky issues that refuse to go away. The Zardari-Sharif accord may score heavily on symbolism, but a number of questions remain about how exactly the new government plans to effect change. The devil, as they say, is in the detail. Given the history of palace

**THE RIFT IN PPP OVER THE LEADERSHIP ISSUE COULD AFFECT THE FUTURE OF THE COALITION.**